



No pressure: “I just want to stay healthy and remain associated with the sport. If I can win another big title, that would be amazing. But there’s no longer a sense of ‘I have to’. I just want to enjoy it and be present,” says Rohler.

he doesn’t see it as something super holy or precious like adults do. For him, it’s just this heavy golden thing. He’d rather just play.

To him, I’m just dad — not an Olympic champion. And honestly, that’s the way I prefer people to deal with me. I don’t want anyone to think I’m some sort of superhero. I’m just one of the guys who played sports and made it to the top. We too often forget all the people along the way who helped make me that champion — the training group buddies, the coaches, and everyone around me, including my family — they’re important too.

The medal is, of course, nice, but the one thing I really like to have around me are my competition bibs. Those are my only real mementos. I keep all my bibs. Sometimes people ask me for one, and I can’t give it to them because I only have one for each competition, which I keep for myself.

You were at your peak between 2016 and 2019, after which you suffered an injury. How hard was

it to come back from that?

If you play at the highest level of sport, you always have to be prepared for something to happen. I was extremely lucky to avoid any major injuries — in what is a very injury-prone event — for nine years in a row. But in 2020, I was really pushing myself in training. And when you go for that high-risk approach, you can get high rewards — but there’s also a downside. For me, it was that back injury. It happens. You need to accept the situation and keep working through it. I needed a lot of patience because it took a long time to recover. It was especially strange to have that injury during COVID, which was such an unusual time. The whole world of sport felt different. Even though I missed the Olympics, I think it was easier to deal with because competing in those ghost competitions was never that appealing to me. Honestly, even if I had been in good shape, I would’ve struggled to compete then. There was no emotion left in the sport. It wasn’t really the sport we love. There was no engagement with fans. Because of that, I was able to focus on my rehab and do all the boring stuff without feeling like I was missing out on throwing the javelin.

Of course, I missed throwing, and it was tough sometimes to watch competitions. But I think it helped that I had already picked the big

fruits of being a professional athlete. I had the Olympic and European golds. I’m very happy and satisfied with what I’ve already achieved in sport. So the injury became a personal challenge — to also accept the bad parts of sport.

Was there ever a moment where you felt like you didn’t need to push yourself and deal with the heartache of missing a second Olympics?

You do have bad days, and on those days, you feel like quitting. Sometimes you don’t train either. But then, two days later, you start to miss that feeling. I’ve told myself that I’ll continue to compete as long as I still have that feeling of missing training. As long as that stays alive, I’m going to keep training.

I think I’m blessed to be able to do what I do. I know many talented people who would love to do this, but they have to take the nine-to-five route. I’m lucky enough to do this at a really high level. It’s not like I’m throwing at a city level. I’m still one of the world’s best javelin throwers. I’m throwing above 80 metres. And that’s something I’m pretty happy about.

Were you always interested in being a javelin thrower?

I loved throwing stones from the shore when I was a small kid. I’d say I just had this throwing gene. But I was a very skinny, small kid. I wasn’t big and strong like the other boys at the beginning. [He’s currently 6’3”] So early on, I tried my luck in the more technical events. I started out as a high jumper and triple jumper.

That made a lot of sense because, if you want to stay in the high school sports system in Germany, you need to meet certain standards. And I just wasn’t hitting those standards with the javelin at the time. So I went into high jumping and met the standards there. But on the regional level, I always competed in throwing.

I was okay. Not great, but okay. And my heart was always telling me that throwing was way more fun. So I invested more time in it. Luckily, I had people who supported that. And yeah, then things went really well. I